apparently with the intent of eradicating PLO strongholds in that region. This put a new monkey wrench in Habib's delicate negotiations with the Palestinians and Syrians.

To reinforce my remarks during the telephone calls, I sent a follow-up letter to Begin the next day:

> This message follows our telephone conversation to emphasize the depth of my personal concerns about recent Israeli military actions and their destructive effect;. . . at this crucial moment in Ambassador Habib's mission, when he is only a few days away from working out the final detailed points of his package plan for departure of the P.L.O. from Beirut, Israeli air strikes, shelling and other military moves have stopped progress in the negotiations. I find this incomprehensible and unacceptable. Israel must adhere to an immediate strict cease fire in place. The assurances which we hear from Jerusalem must be borne out by the actions of Israel's defense forces, who must stop these massive eruptions to any provocation. I cannot stress to you enough how seriously I regard this situation. Our entire future relations are at stake if these military eruptions continue . . . the Ambassador must be able to fulfill the last steps in his mission. Israeli military actions of the past several hours may have made further alteration of the package impossible. If this proves to be the case, we will look to Israel to accept it fully so the agony of Beirut will end . . . I cannot accept this new military advance as compatible with pledges of Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon and support for the emergence of a stable Lebanese government. . . .

Begin replied the following day, explaining that he had not responded immediately to my message because his wife had decided not to awaken him when it arrived the night